

Canvas, Chennai's newest bar, pairs fun cocktails with bold food and live music **P2**

HUMA: 'SMALL-SCALE FILMS DESERVE A CHANCE' **P4**

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On a searing July morning I walk among rows of birds-of-paradise lining the pathways around the recently-renovated Victoria Public Hall. It is not often that you interview an author at a place that also features in the opening pages of his debut novel.

Zhayynn James's *The Keeper of the Wells*, published by Notion Press, is a centuries-spanning, continent-traversing family saga that opens a hundred years ago in colonial Madras, travels to Europe and returns to the city at a time when it was still an outpost of the Empire on the eve of the Second Anglo-Mysore War (1780-84). What strings this kaleidoscopic narrative – of European and Indian powers at play, the battle for the Carnatic, the lives of those at Fort St George and outside its ramparts – is the story of an Irishman John Nicholas, his descendants, and the legacy they were bequeathed by the East India Company for saving the inhabitants of the city from a cruel fate.

Zhayynn, a second-generation landscape architect and award-winning wildlife photographer who has been featured in *National Geographic* and *BBC Wildlife Magazine*, among others, was raised in Adambakkam on the outskirts of Chennai. "It was a childhood spent running wild among sparrows, frogs and trees, peppered with a robust dose of Anglo-Indian optimism," says Zhayynn, who is an old boy of St Bede's, Madras Christian College, and the University of New South Wales. But all through those years, Zhayynn knew there was more to his family genealogy than just mixed race parentage.

"My mother Marlene was a Nicholas and it was her parents who told me stories of an Irishman who saved Madras from the machinations of Hyder Ali and how we were descended from that stock. I'm the eighth generation. That story resurrected itself during family get-togethers and all the more during funerals when various



The wheel of fortune

In his debut novel *The Keeper of the Wells*, Zhayynn James weaves a saga of love and memory that inextricably links his Anglo-Indian family with a well-known neighbourhood in Chennai

Nicholases were constantly being introduced and identified. It was at my grand-aunt Kitty's funeral that I discovered the inextricable link the Nicholas family shared with an old Madras neighbourhood – the Seven Wells."

When Zhayynn was in his twenties he realised that the distance between the older generation that remembered these stories, and his generation that struggles to remember it was widening, and

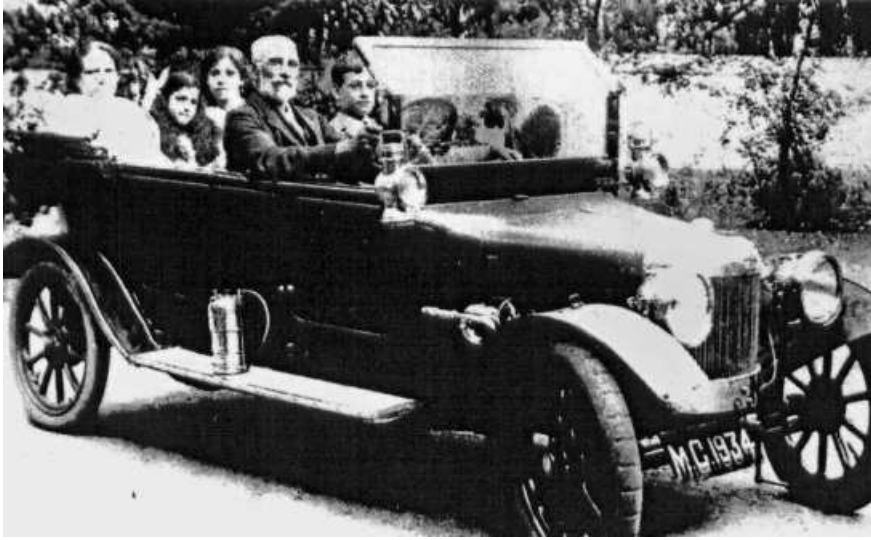
that this legacy may not even be a footnote in the history of Chennai unless he did something about it.

Finding his way

Three serendipitous occurrences led him to write the book – the first was his meeting with that renowned old Madras hand and chronicler, S Muthiah, who pointed him in the direction of three books – HD Love's *Vestiges of Old Madras*, JC

Molony's *A Book of South India* and his own *Madras Rediscovered* that historically mentioned the Nicholas family as the Custodians of the Seven Wells, a locality in North Madras where wells were sunk to supply fresh water to Fort St George, making it the first piped water supply in British India. The second was discovering the Nicholas square at the St Roque's Cemetery in Washermanpet where generations of

City chronicle (Clockwise from left) Zhayynn James at Victoria Public Hall; the last custodian of Seven Wells, Eveyln Nicholas, his wife Millicent, and their children Connie, Gwen and Harold in 1916 at the Seven Wells compound driveway; and the book. B JOTHI RAMALINGAM AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Nicholases had been buried and are still laid to rest. The third was Zhayynn's wife Vaishali's constant encouragement – she kept him company while he researched on the family, pushing him to complete the book in time for his 50th birthday.

At the launch of the book at Victoria Public Hall with a galaxy of panellists that included historian Sriram V, publisher-writer-filmmaker Harry MacLure and writer Ranjitha Ashok, with Sujatha Giri hosting the evening, Sriram spoke about "how important it is to have a book like this. Creating a romantic interest in history will draw more readers to it. 'Faction' (a portmanteau of fact and fiction) books such as these ignite the imagination. Nicholas, as per Molony, saved the water supply during 'the stormy days of Hyder Ali's conquest and was named Custodian of the Seven Wells'. Not just that, the title and

emoluments that went with it were bestowed on the family for 125 years".

While Harry underlined the Anglo-Indian contribution to India and Ranjitha drew attention to the incorporating of family moments within a historical framework, Zhayynn spoke of how after living with the story for decades he finally put pen to paper in October 2025 and finished the book in April.

Zhaynn says that a fascinating story that has been passed down generations is of how John Nicholas etched the map of a fort where he was held prisoner on his thumb nail. Influenced by the writings of Bernard Cornwell and Louis L'Amour who both wrote of swashbuckling heroes and damsels in distress, Zhaynn says he wove in a love story because "Madras was a cosmopolitan city even in the 1700s with its mix of Luso-Indians, British, Telugus and Tamils. Beyond the city on the brink of war I wanted a nuanced and layered love story".

The book written at a racy pace but with a touch of old-world charm and a vocabulary that seems to have

fallen off the map, has many descriptive scenarios worth remembering. The battle scenes are a masterclass in detail and atmosphere.

The book opens in a gentler time but its narrative energy comes from Zhayynn's deep research – combing through church records with his mother in tow: at St Francis Xavier's Church, Broadway, and St Mary's Co-Cathedral, Armenian Street, research at the British Library, London, and trawling the Internet. "The oldest physical record was from the 1840s. I also am indebted to all the Nicholases, about 40-odd now, around the world. Nigel, a distant cousin, whom I discovered in the course of my research, willingly shared the information he had gathered. And I knew I was on the right track when every date mentioned matched with history. However, the Indian names of the people they married were just entered as Indo-Brit."

Zhayynn wrote in cafes, between breaks at work, and late into the night. He also wrote with the inherited DNA of a man who had arrived on these shores looking for escape, survival and redemption.

As for Seven Wells, it still stands, shrouded in shrubbery with only one functioning well. But it survives – as a busy neighbourhood, a pincode, a family saga, a book, and one man's record of the role his family played in shaping the history of Madras.



The oldest physical record was from the 1840s. I knew I was on the right track when every date mentioned matched with history

ZHAYYNN JAMES

Life in frames

Photos on display at the Lalit Kala Akademi; and (third from left) the young photographers from Ramanathapuram. B VELANKANNI RAJ



this new, young set of photographers for *Lives Among The Palms* as well," says P Sainath, journalist and founder, PARI.

Carnatic singer, author and activist TM Krishna highlights the importance of how the young photographers are getting to tell their own stories, and called the exhibition a powerful way of bringing attention and an archival documentation of their everyday lives.

"It is very interesting to see what their perception is, at their age. The young photographers have also acquired skills, and the ability to grow which is very impactful. The communities and the labour that makes up the subject of their stories and photographs are often invisible, despite the fact that all our lives in some way depend on all the work you are seeing, captured in these photographs," he adds.

Today is the last day to catch Lives Among The Palms, at Lalit Kala Akademi, Greams Road, from 10am to 7pm.

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We pick a headlamp from a stack laid out on a table in a corner of the Lalit Kala Akademi gallery, before pushing aside a curtain and stepping into a room that is dark. The beams of our lamps sweep across the walls and photographs slowly emerge. There are tall palmyrah trees, and nearly camouflaged by the foliage, workers balance precariously as they harvest palm sap, high above the ground.

Sakthi Muneeswari, a Class XII student from Keezhaallikullam village in

Ramanathapuram who has shot these photographs, points to her uncle and aunt in these frames documenting workers at the palm groves in her village.

"They work well into the night, and wear these headlamps. They are so high up from the ground and hidden from view; often we realise there is a worker in a tree only if we hear a sound," she says.

Photographs by Sakthi, and six other student photographers, Munees Prabha, Aathi Selvan, Moniga S, J Jebamalai, T Pon Lakshmi, and P Janani, from in and around Sayalkudi in Ramanathapuram district are now on display at the gallery,

Reading the palm

Student photographers from Ramanathapuram document landscapes, labour, and challenges around them

as part of an exhibition, *Lives Among The Palms*. This documentation of the lives, labour, landscapes and the everyday of the workers from the palmyrah belt and coastal communities there, is the result of an initiative by photographer Palani Kumar, founder of the People's Photographer's Collective (PPC), in collaboration with the Rural Workers Development Society (RWDS)

with the support of The People's Archive of Rural India (PARI).

"We strongly believe in going out into the field, and have been working with students across the country, in rural areas to teach them photography and encourage them to document and narrate their lives. For over one-a-half years, we worked with seven students from Ramanathapuram district,

introducing them to photography, and encouraging them to document their lives and the people around them," says Palani.

Armed with simple cameras and encouraged to shoot in manual mode, Palani says that the students set out to capture a host of stories around them; the hard labour that many of their family members endure in palm

groves or at salt pans, toiling through the long months of summer, battling recurrent water scarcity and more.

The exhibition also served as a backdrop for the TM Krishna- PARI Award 2026, which recognised seven young photojournalists, K Ravikumar, K Hairunisha, K Noor Nisha, K Mukesh, S Keerthi, Suba Gomathi Muppudathi, and R Karthikeyan.

"PARI's mandate has always been that we generate journalism within communities that are easily, and conventionally excluded. We have published photos clicked by these seven awardees and in the future, will publish photos clicked by

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I have some good news and some bad news. The good news is that Chennai's millennials are finding home in bars where the music is well curated, food is spiced right, and the bartenders are always ready to serve what we are craving. The bad news however, is that these places are becoming increasingly difficult to keep to ourselves. Gatekeeping is a lost art. To that list comes the almost year-old Canvas on Chamiers Road which has just added cocktails to its repertoire. Until now, this almost 6,000 sq ft space was largely an all-day café. Its new evening programme brings together a cocktail menu, an expanded food offering and a music programme that switches up over the weekends, transforming the space into one that makes for a great sundowner. Previously located on TTK Road, Canvas was a café with a global menu, and the new location is an elevation of that spirit. "We are highlighting Southeast Asian cuisine: Thai, Malaysian, Vietnamese, Indonesian..." says Chef de cuisine, Boy Syahputra Ginting from Indonesia. The drinks menu follows a similar brief. It focusses on balanced cocktails that draw inspiration from Asian ingredients and pair with the kitchen's flavour-forward dishes. First on the menu is Kyoto Sunrise, a yogurt-washed gin-based cocktail with matcha and vanilla. It has a



Raise the bar (Left) Whiskey-based Old Smoke cocktail; (inset) lamb rendang, SANGITA RAJAN AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

With a new cocktail menu, and Southeast Asian fare rooted in Indonesian tradition, Canvas makes a compelling case for staying out a little longer

pink hue that matches the upholstery and wallpapers, and each sip reveals all its layers. Bar Operations manager Thulasiraman sets down our next drink with a smile. "This is on the sweeter side. A milk washed vodka-based cocktail," he says as the Jasmine Reels is served with a small serving of caramelised popcorn on the side. The sesame, caramelised popcorn syrup, and cacao jasmine vodka sound like an odd combination, but go together smoother than anticipated. **Food to the fore** Each drink is marked with a level of strength and, with each sip, it becomes clear that the cocktails are built with the food in mind. Start with the Vietnamese rice paper rolls and the Philadelphia cigars. The former is fresh but a little under-seasoned, while the latter arrives crisp, creamy and disappears almost as quickly as it is served. The som tam, available in both vegan and vegetarian versions, is loaded with peanuts and chillies, offering just the right balance of crunch, heat and tang. Soon, chef Boy sets down trays of sushi and dumplings with an array of dips from chilli garlic and sesame soy to yuzu aioli and a hoisin honey glaze. Brushing up on our chopstick skills, we try the asparagus uramaki and the California roll both of which are flavourful even before we bravely dollop wasabi and pickled ginger over each bite. The chicken and shrimp siu mai and the edamame dumplings have well-seasoned fillings and the chilli garlic dip lends the right amount of heat. Fortunately, the next round of cocktails arrives at the right time. Thulasi returns with the Mad Adam, made with lime, mint and dark rum which is bright and citrusy. Eye Candy, a rum-and-lychee cocktail was layered with notes of melon. Both are refreshing palate cleansers before the mains make their entrance. Be cautious with the Old Smoke, a sesame-infused whiskey cocktail which is smoked and heady, and not everyone's cup of tea. As inviting as a pesto sourdough pizza sounds, and tastes, skip right ahead to the rendang curry with some jasmine rice. The rendang at Canvas is not merely a "braised lamb in spiced coconut with chilli and turmeric" like the menu suggests. Behind the scenes, chef Boy gets in touch with his roots, grinding the spices from scratch and roasting them with the lamb, coconut and fresh red chillies for over eight hours. "Rendang is

not a dish, its a technique. We cook the chilli, turmeric, coconut and spices for a long time and make it almost dry. It is a method of preservation and in my hometown we would make rendang and store it for months," he says reminiscing. The result is deeply savoury with tender lamb or taro for a vegetarian variation that yields at the slightest nudge of a fork. The nasi goreng is comforting, the rice smoky from the wok and topped with a crisp-edged fried egg that ties the dish together. If you are dining in a group, it makes for an easy centrepiece alongside some chicken or tofu satay which falls a little flat without the deeply savoury peanut sauce. While the food gives Canvas its identity, the music gives it its rhythm. Rather than relying on high-volume popular playlists, the bar leans into jazz, blues, bossa nova, indie and more. A small stage hosts live bands and DJs on the weekends, while the weekday soundtrack is curated by DJ Manny, who also helps programme the venue's live gigs and some vinyl listening sessions in the future at the upstairs space which is currently used to host private events. So yes, the good news is that Chennai has another bar worth making a night of. The bad news? You might want to make a reservation before everyone else catches on.



Canvas is at 77, Chamiers Road, RA Puram. A meal for two with cocktails is ₹3,500. For reservations, call 7824810990.

Heritage on a leaf

House of Venu Krishna, housed in a 120-year-old choultry, offers Andhra meals and tiffin steeped in history



Vintage charm House of Venu Krishna brings together history, architecture and Andhra cuisine. SRINATH M

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It is hard to imagine that such a spacious building exists amid the congested lanes of Chennai's George Town. It is only when I step into the palatial 120-year-old heritage structure that I truly believe it. House of Venu Krishna serves Andhra-style meals and snacks. "My father, Y Venugopal, is a well-known pulses merchant in this area. During the pandemic, the owners and trustees of Vupputur Alwar Chetty Choultry were looking to lease the property and repurpose the heritage building," says Ram Teja, who subsequently took the property on lease and launched House of Venu Krishna. "The owners were keen on preserving the 4,800 sq ft structure, allowing only minimal alterations and refurbishments. As a result, the renovation took nearly two years, and work on the first floor is still under way," he says. "Though we were not in the hospitality business earlier, we have long been part of the food supply chain. That enables me to source the finest ingredients directly from their places of origin. We procure six varieties of chilli from the Guntur region, tamarind from Tumakuru in Karnataka, peppercorns and turmeric from Araku Valley, and rice and pulses from the Nellore region," he says. As we settle down for lunch, a fresh banana leaf is laid out

and the meal begins with a serving of kesari. This is followed by roti pachadi (thogayal), dondakaya vepudu (ivy gourd roast), carrot poriyal, vada, pappad and mango pickle. Ram has assembled a team of cooks from Nellore who specialise in regional delicacies. All the spice powders used at the restaurant are prepared in-house. "Our pappu podi (paruppu podi) and ghee seem to have struck a chord with guests," says Ram. Soon, piping hot rice is served on the banana leaf, followed by a generous drizzle of ghee. Mixing a portion of the rice with the fragrant pappu podi feels deeply satisfying, almost like dining at home. The Andhra-style sambar here differs noticeably from the version commonly found in Tamil Nadu. It is less tangy but decidedly spicier, with a liberal use of both red and green chillies. The daily menu also includes pappu (toor dal cooked with spinach), rasam, perugu pulusu (moru kuzhambu) and buttermilk. In the evenings, the restaurant serves a range of Andhra tiffin specialties, including chilli bajji, punugulu, pesarattu, various dosas, idli and roti. Weekends are particularly busy, and the restaurant can accommodate nearly 120 diners.

House of Venu Krishna is located on Govindappa Naicken Street in Sowcarpet. For enquiries, call 9841398128. A vegetarian meal is priced at ₹200.

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Cafes come and cafes go, but the need for a space to unwind goes on forever. In 2018, at the cusp of the booming café scene in Chennai, a new café found its way to a celebrity's Instagram story. The story goes as all stories do. A rise and fall in customers. Some became regulars, some kept coming in to spot celebrities and some genuinely fell in love with the dynamite prawns being served. Summer House Eatery, the brightly lit space, was shut earlier this year, leaving behind a familiar question: in a city where cafés have become as transient as trends, what fills the void they leave behind? The answer comes in the shape of DUCA, a café that promises to be that space where you can grab a delicious bite to eat, work, relax, and even bring along your furry friends. "When we took over Summer House, we wanted to change everything from interiors and menu to the ambience. In the heart of Alwarpet, you won't find many quiet places where you can truly unwind, so we were determined to make it a space like that," says Yoganandan Guruswamy, owner, DUCA. Currently, the 2,500 sq ft space includes an outdoor space, complete with coolers and misting machines to keep you cool in Chennai's year long summers. There is also a dedicated space for a fully functional wood fired pizza oven. While the menu has undergone changes, what sets it apart are the Indian touches that have been added to a global menu.

The result is a menu that travels through the map of the world, and makes multiple stops in India in places like Maharashtra, Chettinad, Lucknow and more. We are compelled to begin with a strong cup of Vietnamese coffee brewed over condensed milk at the table. The coffee drips down at leisure, setting the tone for the evening. One of the signature offerings at DUCA is the mirapakaya bajji, a classic Andhra street food of snacky chillies, stuffed with peanuts, tamarind and served with onions and a squeeze of lemon. It packs a punch and is not for the faint-hearted. The Chettinad lamb chops are



The duke and I

In the ever-changing landscape of Chennai's café scene, DUCA is betting that thoughtful food, greenery, and an unhurried atmosphere are a combination worth returning for

tender and spiced to the standards of its namesake. An ode to Summer House, the dynamite prawns remain on the menu, tasting just as they always did – tender, saucy and fresh. The bread for sandwiches, burgers and toasties at the café is made from scratch, and it shows. The Nashville chicken burger and its vegetarian counterpart the gobi tikki burger are served on the softest burger buns that remind you of a traditional bakery you would visit as a child. Served with kettle cooked chips with salt and pepper, it is a



Dine and unwind (Right) Interiors of DUCA; (below) burgers served with kettle cooked chips. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

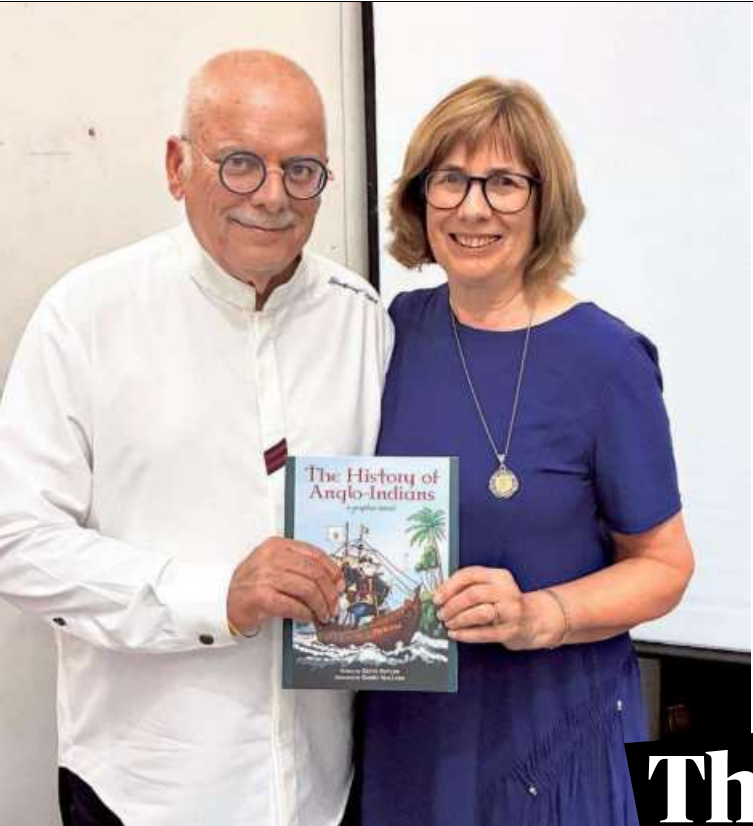
STEP OUT



Goa in a glass The Leather Bar welcomes Petisco for an exclusive one-night bar takeover led by Goa-based bartender and beverage consultant Dev Narvekar. Known for its progressive approach to food and beverages, Petisco brings Goa's vibrant flavours to the glass with cocktails inspired by local produce, traditions and indigenous spirits like feni, blending modern mixology with regional influences. Highlights include the spirit-free Kokum Painkiller, made with kokum, pineapple, orange, lime and milk wash, and the Cheeky Chickoo, featuring Suntory Toki whisky, chickoo, miso, agave, peanut chicki and milk wash. @The Park, Nungambakkam. July 18, 8pm onwards. For reservations, call 984024991.



The Vietnam table Experience the flavours of Vietnam in the city with a curated Vietnamese Food Festival, at Madras Kitchen Company. The menu features favourites such as pho, banh mi, fresh spring rolls and Vietnamese coffee, along with comforting bowls of noodle soup. The festival will showcase Vietnam's street food culture with fresh ingredients, herbs and traditional cooking techniques, complemented by Vietnamese-themed music for an immersive dining experience. @The Westin Chennai, Velachery. On till July 19, lunch and dinner. For reservations, call 89398 92056.



Missing chapter (Clockwise from left) Keith Butler and Robyn Andrews; a 1951 image of the winners of the Anglo-Indian schools' table tennis championship in Calcutta; at an Anglo-Indian ball held in Madras; and Harry MacLure. SHREYA BANERJEE AND THE HINDU ARCHIVES



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For generations, Anglo-Indians have worn their history in plain sight. It lingered in Elvis Presley-inspired pompadours, dance halls and English spoken with an unmistakable cadence. Passed down across dining tables, church choirs and Christmas gatherings, much of their history has remained oral, remembered, but not recorded.

On July 11, inside Kolkata's 167-year-old Dalhousie Institute club that has itself long served as a social and cultural home for generations of Anglo-Indians, that history found life in the form of a graphic novel launch.

The History of Anglo-Indians, published by Anglo Ink, written by author, humorist and satirist Keith Butler, and illustrated by Chennai-based filmmaker and illustrator Harry MacLure, is a graphic novel whose plot traces the history of the Anglo-Indian community from 1498 ie from Vasco da Gama's arrival in Calicut to 2026 Kochi, as the town hosted the 13th Anglo-Indian World reunion.

For Keith, the project grew out of years of research. For Harry, it became an intensely personal labour that occupied almost a year of his life. Speaking about the premise of the book, Keith juxtaposes it with his previous novel, *The Secret Vindaloo*. He talks about the novel's protagonist 'Puttla' Marks. "I wrote it from the point of view of Puttla Butler (himself). I knew our history had been eclipsed. We had been erased from it. When I went to

The memory keepers

Chennai illustrator Harry MacLure teams up with author Keith Butler on *The History of Anglo-Indians*, a hand-drawn graphic novel

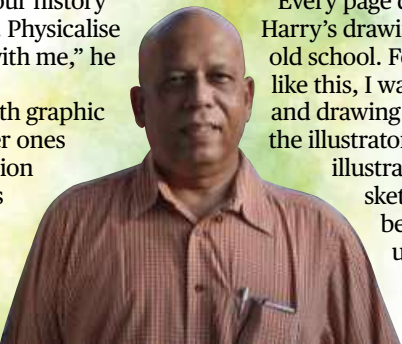


documenting Anglo-Indian life. He founded and edits *Anglos in the Wind*, a community magazine that has chronicled Anglo-Indian life for nearly three decades. Yet this book was not simply about illustrating characters. It required visualising an entire civilisation whose influence often exceeded its numbers. "The community is over 500 years old. You cannot tell that story chronologically inside one book. Keith spent more than three years researching, writing the dialogues and building the script. Somehow he managed to bring five centuries together in a nutshell," he says.

Every page drew breath on Harry's drawing board. "I'm old school. For something like this, I wanted pencil, ink and drawing boards," says the illustrator. Each illustration was first sketched by hand before being inked using Staedtler pigment liners. Only then came colour, speech

writing school, they told me, 'Don't just say your history has been erased. Physicalise it.' That stayed with me," he thunders.

"This is my 13th graphic novel. The earlier ones were science fiction and fantasy. This one was personal," says Harry. Harry is no stranger to



balloons and page layouts. Comic books, he explains, are drawn at twice their printed size so that every line remains crisp when reduced. One panel depicting the Jallianwala Bagh massacre proved almost impossible to complete. "It was around 2.30 in the morning. Everyone was asleep. It was raining outside. Drawing innocent men, women and children being shot, I almost broke down. After finishing that illustration, I couldn't continue," Harry recalls.

Other moments however brought unexpected joy. A sequence showing Anglo-Indians travelling by train between Villupuram and Puducherry reminded him of his own childhood. "I'm a railwayman's son. My father drove steam locomotives. I grew up riding those great iron horses with him," he remembers. Few professions are as closely associated with Anglo-Indian history as the Indian Railways. For generations, the community worked as drivers, guards, engineers, station masters and workshop staff, helping build one of the world's largest railway networks.

A homecoming

"Nobody taught us Anglo-Indian history in school," Harry says. "We learnt it from our parents, grandparents, uncles and aunts. It was passed down orally."

Anthropologist Robyn Andrews, Keith's wife, says that the audience of the book extends well beyond the community itself because it also traces the history of India and how migration shaped it.

Every civilisation is, in the end, an accumulation of arrivals. The Anglo-Indian community was born of one such encounter and went on to leave its imprint on India's culture. Yet much of that inheritance survives more vividly in family memory than in official history. The book is an attempt to correct that imbalance, recovering a community whose story has too often been told in fragments and returning it, panel by panel, to the larger narrative of the subcontinent.

Spotlight on Ravana

Ganesh V Shivaswamy examines the legal controversies surrounding Raja Ravi Varma's painting of Ravana

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Raja Ravi Varma has been in the news this year for many reasons, most notably after his *Yashoda* and *Krishna* sold for a record ₹167.2 crore. Yet, beyond auction houses and gallery displays, the celebrated artist's works have been at the centre of public debate, legal disputes, and cultural conversations.

An upcoming talk by Ganesh V Shivaswamy, advocate, author, and adjunct professor at the National Institute of Advanced Studies (IISc), Bengaluru, will explore the lesser-known legacy, examining how Ravi Varma's art reached far beyond royal patrons and collectors to engage wider public discussion.

Titled *Raja Ravi Varma's Ravana in Conflict and Controversy*, the talk traces how the image became entangled in court cases, discussions on scientific evidence, Government acquisition of cultural objects, and questions of authenticity and public memory.

"Generally, the greater legacy belongs to Rama. Ravana has always had the lesser narrative around him, that's what makes him so interesting to explore," says Ganesh.

A large part of the talk revolves around how the interdisciplinary intersection of law and art informs the study of cultural history. "In this talk you will notice that one propels another into thinking and deliberating that at some point it starts working together," he says.

One of the cases to be discussed in the talk centres on a petition heard by the Kerala High Court between 2011 and 2012, in which the petitioners sought to have all of Raja Ravi Varma's paintings acquired by the Centre under the Antiquities and Art Treasures Act. Justice Chelameswar declined the plea, holding that the Government could not indiscriminately acquire cultural objects. The judgment became an



Brush battles *Jatayu Vadham* by Raja Ravi Varma. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

important milestone in how legal frameworks shape the preservation and ownership of art.

Ganesh also highlights the case of the Roerich estate (Svetoslav Roerich and Devika Rani Roerich) in Bengaluru. The Government of Karnataka acquired the estate and its paintings in the early 1990s on the pretext that the couple had no heir, stating that the acquisition was intended to create a museum for the general public.

However, in 2026, the Government has done nothing to build the museum; the paintings remain locked away in storage, and the estate was instead slated to become an eco-tourism hub.

"As much as I tell you this is what happened, I don't know all the answers. A big part of the talk is asking the audience, 'what do you think?'," adds Ganesh.

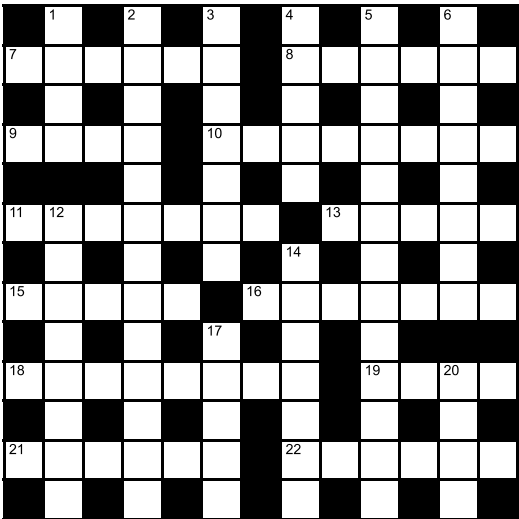
The event will take place on July 19, from 5.30pm, at The Lab, T Nagar. Entry is free and open to all. RSVP on 9940620268.

RAW MANGO SALE JULY 17-20



MALLIGAI,
NO. 2/15 CENOTAPH 1ST LANE,
TEYNAMPET, CHENNAI
11 AM—7PM
+91 89252 86663, 95992 92725

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #62 (Set by Doppelganger)



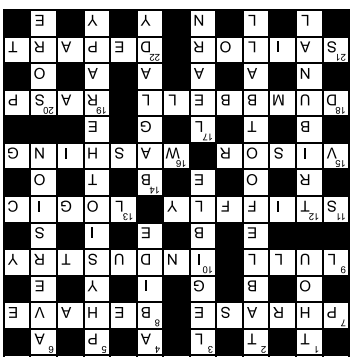
Across

- 7 Meaningful sequence of words (6)
8 Conduct oneself (6)
9 Soothe (4)
10 Diligence (8)
11 Rigidly (7)
13 System of reasoning (5)
15 Eyesshade (5)
16 Act of ablution (7)
18 Exercise weight (8)
19 Coarse file (4)

Down

- 21 Seaman (6)
22 Leave (6)
1 Old form of 'you' (4)
2 US football (5,8)
3 Capable of being read (7)
4 Put up with (5)
5 Massage to relieve pain (13)
6 Intense dislike (8)
12 Law court (8)
14 Homeless woman (3,4)
17 Gain knowledge (5)
20 Tender (4)

Solution No. 62



To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



The art of process

Studio Medium's pre-festive 2026 collection arrives in Chennai through an immersive presentation that explores the relationship between craft, architecture, and the beauty of process. Inspired by the rhythm of the monsoon, the collection translates the movement of water into textiles using bandhani, arashi, shibori, and mothra techniques. An

installation of sculptural shibori canopies, textile artworks, and the studio's signature pateela offers visitors a glimpse into the making of the garments. The collection will be available at Collage, Rutland Gate, from July 17 onwards. For details, call 9500082600.

Banyan Tree's
बरखा महतु
a musical celebration with the maestros

A celebration of monsoons, music and divinity

A fundraiser concert in aid of
Tender Roots Academy of Performing Arts

Ramana Balachandhran (Veena)

Sanjeev Abhyankar with Abhishek Raghuram
(Two Rich Traditions come alive & culminate into Sublime Offerings to Vitthala & Krishna)

Saturday, 1st August 2026 | 5:15 pm
Narada Gana Sabha, TTK Road, Chennai

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Steps to change
Huma Qureshi in *Baby Do Die Do*.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Action block

Actor Huma Qureshi, who plays a hitwoman in *Baby Do Die Do*, on why small-scale Bollywood movies deserve a chance in theatres

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The trailer of *Baby Do Die Do* introduces Huma Qureshi's character as "India's first hitwoman". Huma admits that she loves the title. "I enjoy being called a female action star," she tells *The Hindu*. Released on July 3, the Hindi crime drama has Huma playing a deaf-and-mute assassin. The Nachiket Samant directorial dives into the dark underbelly

of Mumbai, where circumstances force a young girl to become a contract killer. Anurag Kashyap, who introduced Huma to Bollywood with *Gangs of Wasseypur*, threw his weight behind the movie, emphasising the need for giving independent movies a good chance to sustain in theatres. Huma, who has produced the movie with her brother Saqib Saleem, under the banner Saleem Siblings, says the long road to bringing *Baby Do Die Do* to screens

was far from easy. "It takes a lot to put together a female-led action movie," points out Huma, on the sidelines of the Bengaluru leg promotion of *Baby Do Die Do*. "There is a belief that people don't want to watch women in action films, and that female-led action movies don't sell. We don't get the kind of budgets male action movies get. I had to fight to mount this movie," she says. In the film, Huma plays Baby, a highly efficient assassin who uses a seemingly ordinary umbrella as her weapon. She is troubled by her past and is far from the typical larger-than-life assassin. *Baby Do Die Do* has arrived after the massive success of *Maa Inti Bangaaram*, featuring Samantha Ruth Prabhu in the lead. In the Telugu movie directed by Nandhini Reddy, Samantha plays a docile housewife with a violent, action-packed past. I ask Huma if people are responding to the vulnerability and grounded treatment of these characters. "I enjoy action movies that are believable yet have fantastical elements in them, and those that keep you hooked with quirky characters and realistic



world-building," she says. "With *Baby Do Die Do*, director Nachiket and producer Saqib worked on the script for four years, with endless jamming and rewriting. They introduced people to a new world, where a deaf-and-mute female assassin felt believable." *Baby Do Die Do* was released alongside the Alia Bhatt-starrer *Alpha*, the hyped spy thriller and the first female-led installment of the YRF Spy Universe. There is a world of difference between the budgets of the two movies. In fact, the prevailing narrative in the post-pandemic period is that people aren't willing to go to theatres unless it is for a 'spectacle' film. "We love big-budget action dramas. However, we don't always have the means or the tools to make them," says the actor. "I don't have ₹150 crore to make such a film. So, should I not make movies at all? Creativity can come in any size and shape." Huma stresses that small-scale movies need time to build momentum. "We have had a very limited release; it's not even 500 screens. We are constantly figuring out the best centres to release a movie like this. I am finding my audiences, and they are growing slowly. Not every film needs to be declared a hit in the first 72 hours of its release. We must create a model which allows films to breathe and for people to discover them slowly." Huma is awaiting the release of *Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups*, starring Yash and directed by Geetu Mohandas. "It's one of the most ambitious projects of the year," she says, being tight-lipped about her role. "Yash and Geetu are incredibly driven and talented humans. They are trying to do something that's never been done before. I applaud them for it. It's a bonus for me to work with them and get to learn a lot. I am proud to be part of *Toxic*."

Made in Korea
Get a taste of Korean films, as the Korean Story Festival 2026 kicks off in the city. This could be your chance to catch a few handpicked films, like *Everglow*, *Luck-key*, *We are Brothers*, *4th Place* and *Our Midnight*. Put together by the Consulate-General of the Republic of Korea in Chennai, in support with AVM Production and Avichi College of Arts and Science, the chief guest of the festival will be award-winning Tamil filmmaker, Nithilan Saminathan. The festival, open to the public, will screen films from 6pm (July 20-22) at PVR Sathyam Cinemas. Seating on first-come-first-serve basis.



Short take
Filmmaker Anurag Kashyap has launched a YouTube platform for independent short films titled, Oh Flip Shorts. With psychological thriller short film, *Incognito*, dropping first, the platforms aims to drop one title every month. Kashyap said in a statement, "I've always loved short films as they are the first stepping stone for a director to test their storytelling style and give an actual practice to them of shooting a story." Director Ravi Muppa's *Incognito*, which drops first in the platform, follows the story of a cash-strapped motel receptionist who profits off hidden-cam videos.



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When my last breakup hit, my friends intervened with a playlist. It is one of those mixtapes-turned-playlists that has been quietly passed from one broken heart to another, picking up new songs like battle scars along the way. Somewhere in that lineup, between the obvious Taylor Swift anthems, were a few tracks by Prateek Kuhad. Songs like 'Kasoor', 'Kho Gaye Hum Kahan', and 'CO2' have quietly become the soundtrack of heartbreak for an entire generation. The singer-songwriter who found global recognition with his 2018 song 'Cold Mess' – a track

that made it onto former US President Barack Obama's Favourite Music of 2019 list is back with his latest album, *Full Moon Chamber*, four years after his last album, *The Way That Lovers Do*. On a balmy Chennai night, I caught up with Prateek over a call from Los Angeles to talk about his latest album. Recorded between New York and Los Angeles, the album digs into love, identity and belonging through writing that feels personal. Released via Atlantic Records, the album traces a journey from inner turbulence towards a quieter place of calm, love, balance and self-reflection. "Most of it was written in Los Angeles while I was there for writing trips. It was only later, when I looked back at everything I'd written over the last few years, that the themes kind of formed," says Prateek. Los Angeles, where he now spends most of his time, seeped into the record in many ways beyond simply serving as a backdrop. "LA has a very different kind of energy," he says. "There's a big community of musicians and producers here." Several of the album's producers, including Nick Ruth, are based in the city, but Prateek insists the influence came as much from the collaborative environment as from any one artiste. The collaborative side of the album marked a noticeable shift from his earlier work. While most of his previous records began with him writing a song before moving to the

The moon and beyond

Singer-songwriter Prateek Kuhad on the collaborative process behind his latest album *Full Moon Chamber*

production, *Full Moon Chamber* evolved differently. "I almost intentionally stepped back from production. I wanted to work with other people," he says. Despite writing far more than just on heartbreak, Prateek's name remains almost synonymous with it. When asked if it overshadows the broader emotional landscape of his music, he simply shrugs, "It is what it is. I still get to put out music, so that's good enough for me." More than a decade into this industry, and Prateek has also witnessed India's independent music scene evolve dramatically. "It's a more vibrant now," he says.

Full Moon Chamber is currently streaming on all platforms.

Uphill battle

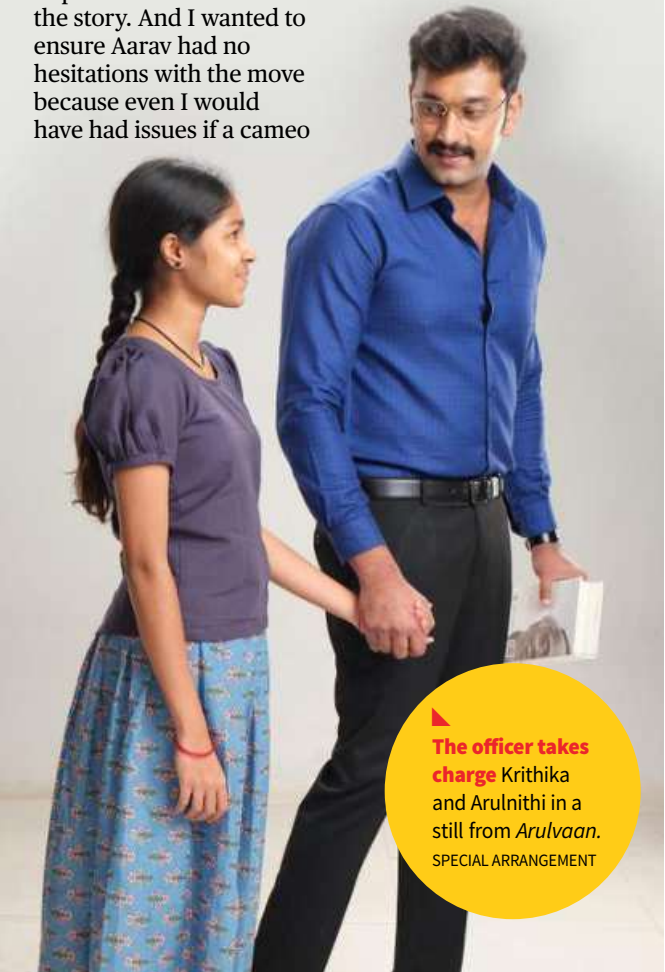
Arulnithi speaks about his upcoming Tamil film *Arulvaan* and whether he feels pressure to stay relevant

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Actor Arulnithi, from his stringently curated filmography, might come across as a serious actor who may be reticent in real life. But those who have had the pleasure of conversing with him know that Arulnithi is a hoot. He throws caution to the wind and opens up like a child eager to show all that he is, and it is on you to curate the parts that make sense to you. "I am just being myself, and I talk to everyone like how I would talk to my friends," he says as we sit down for a freewheeling chat ahead of the release of his film, *Arulvaan*.

Set to release in theatres on July 17, the film marks a reunion between Arulnithi and director Ganesh Vinayakan after their 2013 film *Thagaraaru*. "We have been friends ever since, and one-and-a-half years ago he showed me a 20-minute footage of *Arulvaan* that he had shot. He informed me that there's the character of an IAS officer in the film." However, the star was hesitant as it was then pitched as an extended cameo. "I really liked the script, but I felt it would be better if someone senior did it." Upon Ganesh's request, the actor agreed to do the part, provided his co-star Aarav had no issues with it – especially since the role wasn't just a mere cameo. "Ganesh understated the importance of the role in the story. And I wanted to ensure Aarav had no hesitations with the move because even I would have had issues if a cameo

in my film became such a pivotal role." *Arulvaan*, set in the Western Ghats of Tamil Nadu in the 1990s, tells the story of a young girl named Kurinji and her fight for education. Aarav, Ramya Pandian and Arulnithi play the three characters who take on the system in ensuring the girl, played by Krithika, receives education. "My character is loosely based on the real-life IAS officer Malayappan, who did a lot of good for the education and well-being of the communities living in the mountains. That said, this is not a biopic of him," informs Arulnithi. Shot in parts of Kurangani and Kodaikanal in Tamil Nadu, the film promises to take a gritty look into the lives of the mountain-dwelling communities. Arulnithi has always maintained that he wishes to make films at his own pace – he has made fewer than 20 films in a career that turns 16 this year. But given how many new stars have come up over the last decade, one imagines Arulnithi feels a lot of pressure to stay relevant. "The path other actors chose for themselves is different from the one I have chosen for myself. Sometimes their path may not suit me. So, in attempting to replicate theirs, I shouldn't lose out on my own," he says. It is refreshing to see a Tamil actor confess that the concepts of a hero and a heroine are insignificant in today's cinema. "There are no heroes and heroines anymore; everyone's a character."



The officer takes charge
Krithika and Arulnithi in a still from *Arulvaan*.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

